

Neoclassicism in the USA

By the late 18th century in the United States, ancient Greek and Roman architectural styles had become very popular as they were expressive of the young nation's democratic ideals. The Capitol, with its neoclassical façade and dome, is attributed to William Thornton (1759–1828), Benjamin Latrobe (1764–1820) and Charles Bulfinch (1863–44), and was begun in 1793, following Thornton's plan. Inspired by the Louvre and the Panthéon in Paris, the building is centred on a grand entrance (opposite), framed with projecting wings and accentuated by vertical columns. Initially timber, the dome and rotunda were later rebuilt in stone and cast iron. The third US president, Thomas Jefferson (1743–1826), drew upon Palladian and classical ideals in his designs for the Virginia State Capitol (1788), the Rotunda at the University of Virginia (1822–6), and Monticello House (1768–1809). The White House in Washington DC was designed by James Hoban (1758–1800), following his Charleston County Courthouse (1790–2); Jefferson and Latrobe added the east and west colonnades, for laundry and stables, in the 1900s.

